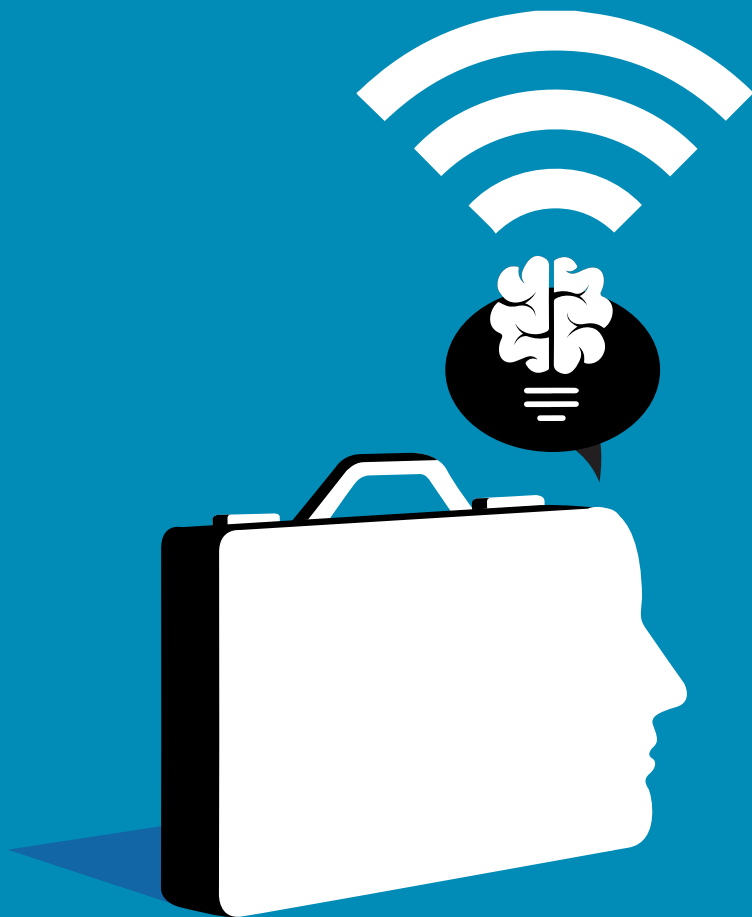




The vision of a tech-driven and knowledge-based economy with strong public finances was amply evident in the Budget announcements

just some examples. For these aspirations to become a reality, not only will we need to innovate continuously, but we also need a supportive regulatory environment. As data moves freely across borders, India has opened its doors to address the global challenge of data security and privacy. For countries and firms looking for digital continuity solutions, the Budget offers a proposal to set up data embassies in GIFT City. This is a welcome move to manage India's regulatory priorities with emerging opportunities.

While some of the initiatives discussed above are very tangible

for the average citizen, there are several programmes that are critical for ease of living and doing business. For example, the proposed National Financial Information Registry will address the problem of asymmetrical information in the financial sector and help companies borrow. Another is the government's efforts to digitise the compliance experience for as-sessees, as that has increased since the inception of GST. The successful implementation of e-invoicing and GST analytics has led to sharpened fraud detection, stricter audit protocols and digital GST forensic tools.

These aspects have helped grow the average GST collections consistently.

Following the trend, the Budget has offered several policy measures to achieve a robust digital economy. However, the most commendable announcements was of using tech to ensure the dignity of every human being. Machine-hole—the concept of using machines to clean sewer holes announced in the Budget—therefore, is both a symbolic and pragmatic solution that defines what India wants to be known for as a nation.

GREEN GROWTH PATH

Even as India spends billions on physical infrastructure and incentivises manufacturing through production-linked incentive (PLI) schemes, championing the green objective is an ethos engrained in Indian tradition. Therefore, the Budget intends to not just increase economic activity, but also make it sustainable in the longer run. There is an all-round focus on the critical aspects of energy transition and energy security paradigm, with an outlay of ₹35,000 crore. The objective is to promote indigenous manufacturing and use innovative tech across new energy areas, including green hydrogen, battery storage and compressed biogas. Basic customs duty has been exempted on imported capital goods/machinery required for manufacturing of lithium-ion cells. Other PLI schemes on manufacturing of battery cells, EVs/fuel cell EVs and auto components will further boost domestic innovations.

So, while India rules the world of IT and allied services, this Budget has laid emphasis on the quantum of tech that is yet to be conquered. The intentions of the government are right, and the conviction displayed by it is that of a developed economy. The bold vision will propel India forward. And collaboration will help us build a better future together. **BT**

The writer is the CEO-designate of Deloitte India. Views are personal